

Chapter 164-2 Final Extra

A day passed, and the night fell dead silent. From time to time, crying and the terrifying sounds of clashing weapons could be heard around them. This dark alley had always been like this—once night fell, no one dared come here anymore.

Rustling sounds came from outside the door, as if someone was talking, then violent commotion erupted. A cold light flashed in Black Scales' eyes, and her body appeared outside the door like lightning.

A frail figure was curled up on the ground. A drunk man was pulling at her, babbling something. Black Scales immediately felt murderous intent. With a sweep of her leg, she kicked the drunk man half a zhang¹ away in an instant.

She didn't care about anything else, pulled the person from the ground into the house, locked the door and closed it.

"You're a medical immortal, a cultivator—how can you not handle a mere drunk!" Black Scales said urgently.

Jiang Li nodded, then shook her head. Her star-like eyes flickered in the darkness, making Black Scales look away.

How could a woman who was once high-spirited with laughter like silver bells appear in such a wretched and filthy place?

Black Scales lowered her head and pulled her up, bringing her into the room. She lit the oil lamp she usually didn't use and examined the places where the drunk had pulled at her. There were no injuries, just torn clothing.

Black Scales' hand swept over that piece of clothing, restoring it to its original state.

But Jiang Li seemed completely unconcerned. She suddenly extended her soft hand and lifted the hair curtain covering Black Scales' forehead. The hideous tattoo crashed into her vision, and Jiang Li hissed.

"Ugly, isn't it?" Black Scales shook her head away and turned to tidy the room, but only unconsciously moved the oil lamp from one side to the other.

"Why?" Jiang Li asked.

"Atonement." Black Scales said in a low voice. She finally decided to put the oil lamp in the center, then smoothed out the coarse cloth on the bed board. "You sleep here. Leave tomorrow."

"Is being a blade mercenary also atonement?" Jiang Li stepped forward and asked.

Black Scales hummed in acknowledgment, then walked out of the room and closed the door, pulling over a broken chair to sit in front of the door.

At this moment the dark clouds had dispersed, and the moon revealed half of its brilliance.

She had originally wanted to end it all, but the national spirit of Xuanyuan State saved her and granted her an immortal body.

Perhaps this was originally the national spirit's final protection for its people, but in Black Scales' view, this was a curse upon her. From then on, she would bear this sin, treating herself in the most painful way, paying it back bit by bit.

Perhaps only this way could she hurt a little less.

This was her sin, but Jiang Li couldn't bear it.

She looked at the moon and wept. Looking and looking, she closed her eyes and fell asleep.

For some reason, Black Scales slept deeply that night. Though usually a light sleeper, she had a dreamless night, only vaguely smelling medicinal fragrance, as if returning to when she first became a disciple, calling out "Senior Sister" in clear, crisp tones, following behind Jiang Li like a little tail.

Those days were good, but they could never return.

When she woke again, the sun was already high. She shielded herself from the dazzling sunlight, bounced up from the chair, and rushed quickly into the house.

The bed was neat and cold, as if no one had slept there. There was no scent of anyone else in the room, and even yesterday's medicine box had vanished without a trace.

She had left. This was as it should be. Black Scales breathed a sigh of relief, numbly polished her dagger, and walked out the door.

Today she had to escort an upright official to a neighboring country, passing through treacherous mountains and ridges crawling with bandits. The journey would take several days. When she returned, it would be as if nothing had happened—she would continue atoning for her sins and praying for her.

This trip indeed took several days. She hadn't used demon power for a long time, only treating herself as a mortal, riding out and riding back. After successfully delivering the person and returning to the city, it was already half a month later.

This day in Anfeng seemed somehow different. The faces of the people coming and going seemed more ruddy, and the faces that always carried bitter expressions now faintly showed smiles.

She grabbed an acquaintance and asked, only to learn that a traveling physician had come from outside, opened a clinic, and charged only one wen² for treatment. The people flocked to get their pulses checked and treated, only to discover this person was actually a miraculous doctor. No matter how difficult the illness, one prescription would cure it completely.

Black Scales closed her eyes. Her originally dead heart was now beating hotly.

She went to look at that clinic. There was no signboard. A woman wearing coarse cloth, her hair bound up, was busy working. Even dressed as a common woman, her beauty could still be seen.

The woman quickly noticed her arrival, put down the medicine box in her hands, lifted her skirt and ran out, her smile like spring flowers in March, dazzlingly beautiful.

Black Scales' heart trembled. She steeled herself and turned to leave, walking in circles to shake the person off. With complicated thoughts, she returned to the dark alley and absent-mindedly lay down on the bed.

When she lay down, her back touched something warm. Only then did she realize there was someone in the room. She suddenly retreated, and when she turned around in shock, she met a pair of clear black and white eyes.

The woman had somehow returned first and was lying quietly on her bed.

"Senior.. Jiang Li!" The moment Black Scales touched her, her heart was completely in chaos. She stumbled back against the door frame, lowering her head and not daring to look at her. "Get out!"

"Get out where?" Jiang Li's beautiful eyes glanced around as she smiled with curved lips.

"Wherever you want to go—back to your Jiang family, back to your immortal realm!"

You are originally the moon on the cliff; why trouble yourself with earthly dust?

"I can't go back anymore." Jiang Li slowly sat up, turned over and got off the bed, walking step by step toward Black Scales. "I resigned from my position as young sect master. Grandmother flew into a rage and forbade me from ever entering the Jiang family gates again in this lifetime."

Black Scales looked up in shock, tears swirling in her dark eyes. She dodged Jiang Li's hand, grasping her wrist to prevent her from touching herself.

"That's your home, your future—you just gave it up like that?" Black Scales couldn't help her anger and spoke sternly.

"I gave it up." Jiang Li said with a smile. She extended her other hand toward Black Scales. Black Scales suddenly turned her head to avoid it, water droplets flying from her face.

"Then go back to the immortal realm. You're the famous Medical Immortal. Even if the Jiang family doesn't want you, the immortal realm will accept you."

"Besides, there are the Divine Venerable and the others. You definitely won't be without a place to go. Why entangle yourself with me!"

Jiang Li had already cornered her. Behind her was the wall corner—Black Scales had nowhere to escape. But Jiang Li still smiled, approaching her gently and tenderly.

The medicinal fragrance from her body kept drilling into Black Scales. Finally, Black Scales could no longer endure it and suddenly pushed her away: "Senior Sister!"

"I beg you, please leave." Black Scales covered her face and knelt down, her curled long hair wrapping around her as she huddled in the shadows, all black.

"I don't want to wrong you..." she sobbed.

But Jiang Li remained calm, as if everything before her meant nothing to her. She slowly crouched down, placed her hand on top of Black Scales' head, and stroked it repeatedly.

With each touch, the body in front of her trembled, like an injured animal. Finally, Jiang Li's eyes moistened. She stepped forward and embraced her, watching her cry with suppressed sobs.

"Senior Sister won't leave. Senior Sister will stay right here with you." Jiang Li gently patted her back, pecking kisses in her hair, kissing and kissing until she reached her lips.

Feeling her lips, Black Scales suddenly shivered, then abruptly raised her hand to push her away. Jiang Li offered no resistance, her body softly falling to the ground.

Black Scales instinctively pulled her back, but the woman on the ground seemed to transform into a snake, clinging on as if she couldn't be shaken off. She wound up along her arm to hang on her shoulder, lifting her head for a kiss.

Black Scales was still pried open by her, tears swimming as they moved.

When the kiss ended, Black Scales no longer moved. She painfully pressed her lips and teeth together, wanting to refuse yet unable to be heartless.

"Senior Sister..."

"Do you still remember the vow we made to our master in the past?" Jiang Li interrupted her.

Black Scales was silent for a while, then spoke: "Travel everywhere with medicine for rulers and subjects, starting with the cold and hungry to make things equal."

"My aspiration to study medicine was never for officialdom but for the people of the world. Now I'm merely leaving the immortal realm—how does this count as destroying my future?" Jiang Li smiled gently. "You want to atone, and I originally wanted to travel and practice medicine. Rather than that, why don't we go together, healing the sick and saving people, doing many good deeds?"

"I'm not excusing you. The past is past. You have sins, and since you can't die, let's carry our guilt forward—what's there to fear?"

"For every person you harmed before, we'll save a hundred people. We'll just keep saving like this, properly atoning for our sins."

"It's mine, Senior Sister..."

"If I hadn't failed to protect you, you wouldn't have fled to death and been captured and controlled by Tianrui³. So I'll help you atone." Jiang Li said word by word.

She pulled out a stack of paper from her bosom, densely covered with names, then smiled: "Look, these are the common people I saved during these three years as a traveling physician. There are already so many. We'll record them all, and there will be many more in the future."

"They will all live because of us." Jiang Li said.

Black Scales took the stack of papers and looked through them. As she looked, tears began to blur the ink, and she could no longer say a single word of refusal.

Jiang Li leaned close and kissed her. Black Scales quickly blushed, then hurriedly moved her hair curtain to cover the hideous scars above.

But Jiang Li kissed the scars instead. Black Scales immediately went soft, leaning forward into Jiang Li's embrace, embracing her waist tightly through her tears.

"Really, Senior Sister? Can I still practice medicine?" she asked carefully.

"Yes." Jiang Li answered with certainty.

After the turmoil ended, Black Scales used her hair to cover her still bright red cheeks and climbed the broken rooftop with Jiang Li, leaning on her shoulder, feeling the evening breeze while looking at the moon.

"I must write a letter about this news to the Divine Venerable. They're also very concerned about you." Jiang Li's words became abundant again, chattering non-stop.

"Oh right, the Divine Venerable and Ning Fuyi got married. Unfortunately, I was searching for you and didn't see it with my own eyes." Jiang Li said with a smile.

Black Scales nestled against her shoulder, listening quietly. Her clear black and white eyes had no time to appreciate the moonlight, only looking at her profile.

"Oh right, do you know there's a strange person in this Anfeng, said to be three chi⁴ tall but with an extremely handsome face..."

"You're still the same as before, not caring about other people's affairs at all." Jiang Li shook her head, then smiled again.

"It's fine. Then Senior Sister will tell you about it..."

Dog barking came from deep in the city. Merchants on West Street were drinking and celebrating, while girls on East Street were still singing and dancing.

The surrounding dark alleys were bloody and chaotic. In the dirty alleys, many cooking fires still rose.

Under the impartial moonlight, they drifted gracefully toward the heavens.

———The End———

Footnotes:

¹ Zhang (丈) - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 11 feet

² Wen (文) - An ancient Chinese monetary unit, a very small amount of money

³ Tianrui (天瑞) - A character name mentioned earlier in the story

⁴ Chi (尺) - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 33 centimeters or 1 foot